

PEPPE MEROLLA

JAZZ DRUMMER · NAPLES → LAS VEGAS



PEPPE MEROLLA
“Little Joe” — from Naples

Frank Sinatra heard him open a show in New York and handed him a nickname that stuck: “**Little Joe.**” Four decades on, Peppe Merolla is the drummer the masters call when the music has to swing — and the one they send their students to.

He came up the right way: the stages and festivals of Italy from age five, a **master’s in classical trumpet** from Naples’ Conservatorio di San Pietro a Majella, then the bandstands of New York. He has powered groups led by **Joey DeFrancesco, Eddie Henderson, Vincent Herring,** and **Jeremy Pelt,** and played the rooms that matter — the Blue Note, Yoshi’s, Smoke, and Smalls.

His debut as a leader, *Stick With Me*, turned a sextet of New York heavyweights loose on a set of fearless hard bop. Singer, classically trained trumpeter, and actor as well as drummer, he works both sides of the Atlantic from his base in Las Vegas.

“*He is an exceptional drummer of the new generation.*”
JOE MORELLO — DRUMMER, THE DAVE BRUBECK QUARTET

Hometown	Naples, Italy	Based in	Las Vegas, Nevada
Training	Conservatorio di San Pietro a Majella, Naples — M.A., Classical Trumpet	Style	Hard bop · Straight-ahead
Instruments	Drums & Percussion · Voice · Trumpet · Piano	Endorses	Canopus · Prologix

01 SELECTED DISCOGRAPHY

- AS LEADER

Stick With Me — debut album as a leader; hard-bop sextet featuring Steve Turre

Sogno Italiano (Italian Dream) — Peppe Merolla & Jazz Mediterraneo (2001)
- INSTRUCTIONAL

For Serious Drummers Only, Vol. 1 — endorsed by Joe Morello, Dave Black & Peter Donald
- EARLY CAREER

As teenage vocalist “Little Joe” — a three-album contract with Zeus Records, plus two records for Visco Disc

02 SHARED THE STAGE WITH

Eddie Henderson · Joey DeFrancesco · Vincent Herring · Frank Lacy · Jeremy Pelt · Steve Davis · Mike LeDonne · Russell Ferrante · Larry Schneider · Gerald Cannon · Enrico Rava · Franco Ambrosetti · John Farnsworth

Italian icons: Andrea Bocelli · Ornella Vanoni · Raffaella Carrà · Katia Ricciarelli · Eugenio Bennato

03 STAGES & FESTIVALS

- Blue Note
- Yoshi's
- Smoke Jazz Club
- Smalls
- Umbria Jazz
- Pisa Jazz
- Siena Jazz

04 PRAISED BY THE MASTERS

David Garibaldi	Tower of Power · funk-drumming legend
Peter Erskine	2× Grammy winner · Weather Report, Steps Ahead, Steely Dan
Horacio “El Negro” Hernández	Grammy winner · Carlos Santana, Michel Camilo, McCoy Tyner
Jeff Berlin	Electric-bass virtuoso · Bill Bruford, Allan Holdsworth, Yes
Gary Husband	Drummer & pianist · John McLaughlin, Jeff Beck, Level 42
Eric Alexander	Tenor saxophonist · One for All; Harold Mabern
Joe Farnsworth	Jazz drummer · Pharoah Sanders, McCoy Tyner
George Fludas	Jazz drummer · Ray Brown Trio, Diana Krall

05 BEYOND THE KIT

- › Orchestra Scarlatti of Naples — drummer & percussionist from age 18
- › RAI International television — alongside Andrea Bocelli, Ornella Vanoni, Raffaella Carrà, Katia Ricciarelli & Eugenio Bennato
- › Scugnizzi (film) — lead role & soundtrack vocalist; an award winner at the Venice Film Festival
- › Educator — online & in-person drum lessons, all levels; clinician for colleges and schools worldwide